

Medicare Help & Benefits

Medicare can be confusing, and mistakes are costly. Free, unbiased counselors help you choose plans and cut costs — and you may qualify for programs that pay your premiums and drugs. Below are trusted national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Get free, unbiased help before choosing or changing plans — the SHIP counselors below don't sell anything. Many people overpay because they don't know about programs that cover premiums, deductibles, and drug costs.

1 Get Free, Unbiased Help

SHIP counselors give free one-on-one Medicare advice with nothing to sell.

☐ SHIP — State Health Insurance Assistance Program

Free, unbiased Medicare counseling in your state. The best first call for any Medicare question.

→ www.shiphelp.org 1-877-839-2675

☐ Medicare.gov — Official Site

Compare plans, check coverage, and find what Medicare pays for.

→ www.medicare.gov 1-800-MEDICARE

2 Lower Your Medicare Costs

Programs that pay premiums, deductibles, and copays for people with limited income.

☐ Medicare Savings Programs

State programs that can pay your Part B premium and other costs. Ask your SHIP or Medicaid office.

→ www.medicare.gov/basics/costs/help/medicare-savings-programs

☐ Extra Help (Drug Costs)

Federal help paying for Part D prescription drugs for people with limited income (up to 150% of poverty level).

→ www.ssa.gov/medicare/part-d-extra-help

3 Understand Your Choices

Know the basic parts of Medicare so you pick what fits — and avoid costly mistakes.

☐ Medicare Basics

Plain-language explanation of Parts A, B, C (Advantage), and D, and when to enroll.

→ www.medicare.gov/basics/get-started-with-medicare

☐ Avoid Late-Enrollment Penalties

Missing your enrollment window can mean lifelong penalties. Learn the deadlines.

→ www.medicare.gov/basics/get-started-with-medicare/sign-up/when-does-medicare-coverage-start

4 Watch for Fraud

Free help spotting and reporting Medicare scams.

☐ Senior Medicare Patrol (SMP)

Free help spotting, preventing, and reporting Medicare fraud and errors.

→ www.smpresource.org 1-877-808-2468

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Medicare will never call to “verify” your number or sell you a plan — those are scams. Hang up and call SHIP or 1-800-MEDICARE yourself. Free SHIP counselors never earn commissions, unlike many plan salespeople.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Review your plan every fall during Open Enrollment (Oct 15–Dec 7) — plans change yearly, and a free SHIP counselor can check whether you’re overpaying for coverage or drugs.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need local Medicare help?

This guide covers national resources. For your state’s SHIP office and local Medicare help, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we’ll connect you with free counseling near you.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
